to their mark, they could send him back to India, albeit in consultation with me.

All set, the weight of the moment started pressing on my shoulders. Having worked through the labyrinth of the French negotiation and the back-and-forth trips to finalise the intricacies of the deal, I was brimming with confidence, but I realised that it was the first time I would be leading such a big team on an endeavour abroad. Dhawan was solidly behind me, and Seshan was always there to help with administrative matters, but I needed much more, some courage of the mind and soul. And who else to turn to than Vikram Sarabhai, who continued to live in me during times of soul searching.

I had learned a lot on man management and delegation from Sarabhai, and this included some lessons on how not to do certain things. Sarabhai's disarming charm was enough to keep his flock together, with no murmur, but bereft of such a gift, lesser mortals like me could not afford to be as lenient with people as the great man was.

Sarabhai's style of letting anyone do anything had baffled me to a level of silent disagreement. There was no iota of doubt that Sarabhai was a man of great vision, but there were times when I felt he, having brought bright Indian scientists from the best of international universities, did not know what to do with them.

This was not lost on Jacques Blamont, a French astrophysicist whom Sarabhai brought as a consultant at the time of setting the Space Science and Technology Centre. Blamont, who was in awe of Sarabhai's energy and optimism, however, had a word of advice to him, 'You need to put your guys in their squares.'

Once I mustered enough courage to ask Sarabhai, 'Do we have a plan of action here?'

Sarabhai had smiled and said: 'The plan will emerge once we let people do what they want and realise what they are good at. I am not sure if it is the right thing to do, but I feel it's the right thing to do now. It's an experiment.'

Never again did I broach the topic.